MODULE II ENGLISH IN THE BRITISH ISLES 450–1500 (Weightage: 25%)

2.1 Language Situation in Britain 450–1500 CE ★ Background

This period is the most linguistically turbulent in English history. It saw three distinct waves of external influence — Scandinavian, then Norman French — layered onto the original Anglo-Saxon base, while Latin continued as the language of the Church throughout. By 1500 CE, English had transformed almost beyond recognition from the Old English of 450 CE.

2.2 Foreign Influences on Old English ★★★ HIGH

★ EXAM TIP

Examiner favourite for both Q1 and Q2. Know all three waves: Celtic (minimal), Latin (two waves: Roman + Christian), and Scandinavian (Viking Age). Give word examples for each.

Wave 1 — Celtic Influence on Old English

As discussed in Module I, Celtic influence on Old English was minimal. The Anglo-Saxon invaders displaced Celtic speakers rather than absorbing them. Place names and a handful of common words (brock, crag, loch) are the main legacy. Celtic influence on Old English grammar was effectively zero.

Wave 2 — Latin Influence (Two Sub-Waves)

Latin influenced Old English in two distinct historical moments, and it is important to distinguish them:

(a) Continental Latin / Roman Period Borrowings

As discussed in 1.5, these entered before the Anglo-Saxons reached Britain. Words for material culture: wine, cheese, street, wall, cup, dish, mile, pound.

(b) Christian/Ecclesiastical Latin (6th–10th centuries)

In **597 CE**, Pope Gregory the Great sent **St Augustine of Canterbury** to convert the Anglo-Saxons to Christianity. With Christianity came an enormous wave of Latin vocabulary — the language of the Church, learning, and manuscripts. This is sometimes called the **second wave** of Latin into English.

✦ EXAMPLES

Ecclesiastical Latin borrowings: angel, candle, hymn, mass, monk, nun, priest, school, disciple, epistle, paradise, temple, font, altar, psalm, minister, pope, creed, martyr, deacon, apostle, pilgrim. Also educational terms: grammar, meter, verse.

Some of these words entered through Greek and were then Latinised before reaching English — words like 'church' (Greek *kyriakon*), 'bishop' (Greek *episkopos*), and 'devil' (Greek *diabolos*). The Christian Latin wave represents a massive enrichment of the English lexicon, particularly in the domains of religion, learning, and administration.

Wave 3 — Scandinavian / Old Norse Influence (Viking Age) ★★★ HIGH

The **Viking invasions** began in **787 CE** (first recorded raid on Lindisfarne, 793 CE) and continued for nearly three centuries. Danish and Norwegian Vikings first raided, then settled large parts of northern and

eastern England — the area that came to be called the **Danelaw** (formally established by the Treaty of Wedmore, 878 CE, between King Alfred the Great and the Danish leader Guthrum).

The Danelaw covered roughly the area north and east of a line from London to Chester. Within this territory, Old Norse and Old English coexisted and mixed intimately — the two languages were mutually intelligible enough that significant borrowing in both directions occurred.

What Old Norse Gave English

The Scandinavian contribution is remarkable because it affected not just vocabulary but **core grammar** — pronouns, prepositions, and common everyday words. This is unusual — grammatical elements are almost never borrowed between languages unless contact is extremely deep and prolonged.

✦ EXAMPLES

Old Norse borrowings — Pronouns: they, them, their (these replaced OE hie, him, hiera). Everyday words: sky, egg, cake, take, call, want, get, give, birth, husband, sister, window, wrong, ugly, happy, loose, low, flat, ill, weak. Verbs: die, ride (in the Norse sense), crawl, gasp, glitter, scare. Place names ending in -by (Grimsby, Derby, Whitby), -thorp (Scunthorpe), -toft (Lowestoft), -ness (Skegness).

■ KEY NOTE

The replacement of the Old English 3rd-person plural pronouns (hie/him/hiera) with Norse they/them/their is hugely significant — even the most basic function words were exchanged. This shows how deeply integrated Scandinavian settlers were in daily Anglo-Saxon life.

2.3 Characteristics of Old English ★★★ HIGH

★ EXAM TIP

Very likely to appear as Q2 (diagram + long answer). Draw a mind-map with five branches: Compound Words, Strong Verbs, Word Order, Winchester Vocabulary, Stress Pattern.

What is Old English?

Old English (OE), also called Anglo-Saxon, was spoken from approximately **450 CE to 1100 CE**. It descended from the West Germanic dialects of the Angles, Saxons, Jutes, and Frisians who migrated to Britain from the 5th century onward. OE looks almost like a foreign language to modern eyes — it has elaborate grammatical inflections, a different vocabulary, and different word order.

The most famous Old English text is the epic poem **Beowulf** (composed between 8th–10th centuries). Other major texts include the *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle* and King Alfred's translations of Latin works.

(a) Compound Words

Old English was highly productive in creating compound words by joining two existing words to form a new concept. This is called **compounding**. OE poetry especially favoured **kennings** — poetic compounds used as metaphorical descriptors.

✦ **EXAMPLES**

Compounds: godspell (god + spell = good news → Gospel), woruldcyning (world-king), tungolcræft (star-craft = astronomy), heofenweard (heaven-guardian = God). Kennings in Beowulf: hronrad (whale-road = sea), beadoleoma (battle-light = sword), goldwine (gold-friend = generous lord).

(b) Strong Verbs

OE inherited from Germanic a system of **strong verbs** that changed their vowel in the past tense rather than adding an -ed ending. This is called **ablaut** or vowel gradation. Many modern English 'irregular verbs' are survivals of this OE strong verb system. There were seven classes of strong verbs in OE, each with a distinct ablaut pattern.

✦ **EXAMPLES**

Strong verbs surviving into Modern English: sing/sang/sung, ring/rang/rung, drive/drove/driven, write/wrote/written, speak/spoke/spoken, ride/rode/ridden, rise/rose/risen, break/broke/broken, freeze/froze/frozen, bind/bound/bound. What grammarians erroneously call 'irregular' verbs are in fact following very regular ablaut patterns from Old English — hence the course objective's statement about 'irregular' forms.

(c) Word Order

Modern English uses a fixed Subject-Verb-Object (SVO) order to convey grammatical relationships. Old English could vary its word order much more freely because it used **inflectional endings** (case endings) to show grammatical function — not position. OE had four cases: Nominative, Accusative, Genitive, and Dative, plus traces of an Instrumental case. In OE poetry and formal prose, **verb-final** (SOV) order was common, reflecting the Germanic heritage.

As inflectional endings eroded (especially under Norse contact, which accelerated this process), English had to compensate by fixing word order. The shift to SVO is one of the most fundamental changes in the history of English grammar.

(d) Winchester Vocabulary

Winchester was the capital of the West Saxon kingdom and became the major centre of learning and manuscript production in Anglo-Saxon England, especially under **King Alfred the Great** (r. 871–899 CE). Alfred's ambitious programme of translating Latin works into English established a **prestige variety of Old English** — Late West Saxon — centred on Winchester. This variety became the written standard for OE, meaning that the OE texts we can read today primarily reflect the Winchester (West Saxon) dialect, not the Anglian or Kentish dialects.

■ **KEY NOTE**

Winchester Vocabulary = the standardised literary vocabulary of Late West Saxon OE, associated with King Alfred's court. It is not a separate dialect but a prestige written form. This matters because: the Norman Conquest of 1066 destroyed Winchester's prestige, and the written standard had to be rebuilt — eventually in London English.

(e) Stress Patterns

In Old English, stress was placed on the **root syllable** — almost always the first syllable of a native word. This is the Germanic stress pattern inherited from PIE. Prefixes in OE could be stressed (when they modified nouns: *ándswaru* = answer) or unstressed (when they modified verbs: *andswárian* = to answer). This distinction between noun-stress and verb-stress survives in some Modern English pairs: PROtest (noun) vs proTEST (verb); REcord vs reCORD.

2.4 Middle English (1066–1500) and the French Influence ★★★ HIGH

★ EXAM TIP

French influence after 1066 is another near-certain Q2 topic. Cover: Norman Conquest context, domains of French vocabulary (law, food, fashion, government), the social stratification (French = elite, English = common), and the eventual re-emergence of English.

The Norman Conquest (1066 CE)

On **14 October 1066**, William the Conqueror (Duke of Normandy, France) defeated and killed King Harold II at the **Battle of Hastings**. This single event had more impact on the English language than any other in its history. The Norman invaders spoke a dialect of Old French (**Anglo-Norman French**), and they became the new ruling class of England — as nobles, clergy, lawyers, and administrators. For the next 300 years, England was effectively **trilingual**:

Language	Used by whom	Domains
Anglo-Norman French	Royalty, nobles, the Church hierarchy, courts	Government, law, literature, religion
Latin	The Church, scholars, official documents	Religion, scholarship, international correspondence
Middle English	The common people, peasants, tradesmen	Everyday speech, agriculture, trade

French Influence on Vocabulary — The Semantic Split

The most striking evidence of Norman French influence is the famous **semantic split** between Anglo-Saxon words for animals and Norman French words for their meat. The Anglo-Saxon peasants who tended the animals used OE words; the Norman nobles who ate the cooked meat used French words. This split has survived to the present day:

Animal (OE/AS word)	Meat at table (OF word)
ox / cow (OE: oxa/cu)	beef (OF: boeuf)
sheep (OE: sceap)	mutton (OF: mouton)
swine / pig (OE: swin)	pork (OF: porc)
calf (OE: cealf)	veal (OF: veel)
deer (OE: deor)	venison (OF: venaison)
chicken/hen (OE: henn)	poultry (OF: poulet)

Domains of French Borrowing

- **Government & administration**

  government, parliament, council, crown, court, state, parliament, mayor, chancellor, minister, sovereign, nation, empire, reign, noble, baron, duke, countess

- **Law**

  judge, jury, justice, crime, prison, defendant, plaintiff, verdict, attorney, pardon, felony, indict, legal, evidence, bail, accuse

- **Military**

  army, navy, battle, war, soldier, sergeant, captain, lieutenant, garrison, castle, siege, enemy, peace, lance, assault

- **Religion**

  saint, prayer, charity, mercy, miracle, abbey, chancel, sermon, piety, grace, devout, faith, divine

- **Food & cooking**

  cuisine, sauce, boil, fry, roast, feast, supper, dinner, appetite, beef, pork, mutton, veal, venison, pastry, biscuit, cream, sugar, salad

- **Fashion & luxury**

  fashion, garment, gown, robe, jewel, diamond, fur, lace, embroidery, perfume, beauty, colour

- **Art & culture**

  art, music, dance, poem, romance, literature, culture, image, beauty, leisure, pleasure

French Influence on Pronunciation and Structure

Beyond vocabulary, French also affected English in subtler ways:

• Pronunciation: French introduced sounds and sound combinations new to English, such as the [v] sound at the start of words (veal, vain, very — OE had no initial /v/), the [d■] sound (judge, gentle, giant from OF), and stress on the final syllable in many borrowed words (hotel, café, machine).

• Spelling: French scribes introduced the spelling convention of for /kw/ (queen, instead of OE cwen), for /t■/ (church had been spelled cirice), and combinations.

• Suffixes: Many French suffixes became productive in English: -tion (nation, action), -ment (government, movement), -ance/-ence (distance, evidence), -ity (dignity, nobility), -ous (famous, curious), -al (royal, legal).

• Word order: French helped consolidate Subject-Verb-Object order by reinforcing the erosion of OE case endings.

The Re-emergence of English

By the mid-13th century, English began its comeback. Several events accelerated this:

• In 1204, King John lost Normandy to the French king. Anglo-Norman nobles could no longer maintain estates in both England and France and had to choose — most chose England, gradually shifting to English.

• The Black Death (1348–49) killed nearly a third of England's population, disproportionately affecting the Latin-educated clergy and French-speaking elite. English speakers filled administrative positions, raising the language's social status.

• In 1362, the Statute of Pleading decreed that court proceedings be conducted in English (not French). In the same year, Parliament was opened in English for the first time.

• Geoffrey Chaucer wrote The Canterbury Tales (c. 1387–1400) in the London dialect of Middle English — this literary prestige accelerated English's re-establishment as a written standard.